

Reading

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The Yılmaz Family: Then and Now

Before you read

- Look at the title. What do you think will be different between the past and now?
- What household chores did families use to share long ago?

The Yılmaz family lives in a busy apartment in Izmir, but their daily routine looks very different from their grandparents' routine fifty years ago.

Today, Mrs Yılmaz wakes up at six thirty, checks her phone, and drives her children to school before going to her office. Her husband works from home three days a week and cooks dinner using recipes he finds online. Their two children, Deniz and Elif, have busy afternoons: Deniz plays football twice a week, and Elif takes a coding class on Saturdays.

Fifty years ago, Mrs Yılmaz's grandparents used to live in a small village outside the city. There was no electricity in the house until the 1970s, and there wasn't a television for many years. Her grandfather used to get up before sunrise to work on the family's small farm, and her grandmother used to bake bread every morning. The children walked to school, and in the evening the whole extended family sat together and told stories, because there wasn't much else to do for entertainment.

One thing that hasn't changed, though, is Sunday lunch. Just like fifty years ago, the Yılmaz family still gathers every Sunday, and relatives from nearby towns often join them. "My grandmother could cook the most delicious dishes with very simple ingredients," says Mrs Yılmaz. "I try to keep some of her recipes alive, even though our lives are completely different now."

Deniz says he sometimes finds it hard to imagine life without the internet, but he loves listening to his great-grandmother's stories about the old village house and its enormous garden.

1. What does Mr Yılmaz do three days a week?
 - a. He drives the children to school.
 - b. He works from home.
 - c. He works on a farm.
 - d. He bakes bread.
2. Mrs Yılmaz's grandparents had electricity from the beginning. — *True / False*
3. Fifty years ago, the family _____ (there was/were) no television for many years.
4. Why did the extended family tell stories in the evening?
 - a. Because they liked reading.
 - b. Because there wasn't much else to do for entertainment.
 - c. Because the grandfather was a storyteller.
 - d. Because it was a school activity.

5. What has NOT changed for the Yılmaz family?

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- a. Their house.
 - b. Their Sunday lunch tradition.
 - c. Their jobs.
 - d. Their village.

6. Rewrite using 'used to': Her grandfather got up before sunrise every day (in the past, no longer true).

After you read

- Compare the Yılmaz family's routine today with their grandparents' routine. What are the biggest differences?
- Do you know any family traditions that have not changed over the generations? Share one.

Homes and Families Around the World

Before you read

- What types of houses do you know from different countries?
- Do you think family size is the same in every country? Why or why not?

Families and homes look very different from country to country, and each type of home tells us something about the people who live there.

In Japan, many urban families live in small, well-organised apartments, often just outside big cities like Tokyo. Homes are usually compact, so families use clever storage and furniture that can be folded away, such as low tables and futon beds. Traditionally, several generations used to live together, but today many young couples prefer their own smaller home close to their parents.

In Morocco, many families live in a riad, a traditional house built around a beautiful inner courtyard. In the past, riads were built for extended families, with grandparents, parents, aunts, uncles and cousins all living together under one roof. There wasn't a strict separation between generations; everyone shared meals and celebrations in the central courtyard.

In Norway, detached wooden houses, called "hytte" for holiday homes, are extremely common, and many nuclear families own a small cabin in the mountains or by the sea. Norwegian families often spend weekends there, hiking, skiing or simply relaxing away from the city.

In Nigeria, extended family networks are very important, and it is common for grandparents, uncles, aunts and cousins to live in the same compound, a group of houses built close together around a shared yard. Children often grow up surrounded by many relatives, and neighbours are treated almost like family members.

These examples show that although family structures and homes are different around the world, the value families place on being together often stays the same.

1. What kind of furniture do many Japanese families use?

- a. Large sofas and dining tables.
- b. Furniture that can be folded away.
- c. Only outdoor furniture.
- d. Antique wooden furniture.

2. A riad in Morocco is built around an inner courtyard. — True / False

3. In Norway, many families own a small _____ in the mountains or by the sea.

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4. What is a compound, as described in the text about Nigeria?

- a. A single large house.
- b. A group of houses built close together around a shared yard.
- c. An apartment building.
- d. A school building.

5. What idea connects all the examples in the text?

- a. All families live in apartments.
- b. All families value being together, even with different home types.
- c. All countries have the same family structure.
- d. All houses have courtyards.

After you read

- Which type of house from the text would you most like to live in? Why?
- Compare a compound or riad with the type of home common in your own country.